cock's classic adaptation of Daphne du Maurier's book *Rebecca* (1938) to the more recent series *Gaslit* (2022) starring Julia Roberts, 'gaslighting' as a concept has slowly caught on in popular imagination in the West, much like 'mansplaining'. Whether the film starts a conversation around it in India remains to be seen, but Khan hopes it will raise awareness and viewers will find her character inspiring. "You don't know that you are a victim of it until much later," she says, "but Meesha is strong-willed and determined in the face of adversity, be it physical or mental. She knows what she stands for and that is admirable."

That surety and sense of purpose have seeped into Khan as well, reflecting in her upcoming choices. She plays freedom fighter and underground radio operator Usha Mehta in Amazon Prime Video's period drama *Ae Watan, Mere Watan*; there's a finished film with Vicky Kaushal; she appears in Anurag Basu's ensemble drama *Metro... In Dino* and in *Murder Mubarak* with Karisma Kapoor. The parts, she adds, are from different worlds, enabling her to present a new version of herself each time. Says Khan, "My only thing is honesty, conviction and realness. If I start polluting that, I won't have anything." It's in this knowledge that Khan is flourishing. ■

Suhani Singh

DOCUMENTARY

JUST NOT CRICKET

Caught Out, a new documentary on Netflix by **Supriya Sobti Gupta**, revisits the biggest scandal to hit Indian cricket







DARK DAYS
(top) Supriya Sobti Gupta and (left) stills from *Caught Out*

Supriya Sobti Gupta is not new to the Indian non-fiction landscape. The 38-year-old filmmaker has served as the producer on two documentaries streaming on Netflix: *Bad Boy Billionaires: India* (2020) and *Mumbai Mafia: Police vs the Underworld* (2023). She is also a former journalist, having worked with organisations like the BBC and Al Jazeera. For her directorial debut, she melded her vocation and profession in a way. Gupta trained her lens on the horrific match-fixing scandal of 2000 that shook Indian cricket to the core. The result is *Caught Out: Crime. Corruption. Cricket*, the recent addition to the slate of non-fiction titles on Netflix.

Gupta says that she was propelled by a desire to shed light on a dark period. "I was interested because it is a retrospective story that involves a lot of emotions, especially for someone like me who grew up watching cricket in the '90s," she says. For long, there were doubts hanging on the gentlemen's game. But it would take persistent journalism and a chance intervention of the Delhi Police in a phone conversation between former South African skipper Hansie Cronje and an Indian bookie called Sanjeev Chawla for the lid to eventually blow. By the end, guilt was scattered all around, including in the then Indian cricket team. Former Indian skipper Mohammad Azharuddin faced a lifetime ban, while Ajay Jadeja and India physio Ali Irani were banned for five years.

Caught Out... works best as a reiteration of the tumultuous time and doesn't unearth new details. This poses a query regarding the need for the outing. Gupta supplies the reason, "I don't think the CBI investigators ever came out like this and shared the burden they carried when investigating the captain of India."

Caught Out... does that. In fact, it frames the narrative around the heroism of the common person more than the dishonesty of the heroes. Journalists and CBI officials populate the frames. Gupta regards them as "unsung heroes". "They stuck their necks out 20 years ago to tell us what happened, and they did it again. They don't enjoy any sort of security and yet, they have made some pretty damning statements," she says. Gupta also reached out to cricketers, including Azharuddin and Irani, but none agreed to talk. "There is a conspiracy of silence," she says.

Even gaining the trust of the officers was not easy. Gupta says having Passion Pictures, the British-based company that has Oscar-winning titles such as *One Day in September* (1999) and *Searching for Sugar Man* (2012) under its belt, as co-producers brought in credibility.

Having said that, *Caught Out...* glosses over some details. For instance, it focuses on Cronje and Azharuddin as the key accused, although many were guilty. The director acknowledges this, but maintains that including them lent a narrative heft, since both were captains. Moreover, she states, "The big CBI inquiry was on Azharuddin and Kapil Dev; with Jadeja, the findings were few." Some exclusions were because of lack of access.

Caught Out... excavates a chapter in Indian cricket history that many would like to pretend never happened. "The writing's on the wall. Have you seen a Virat Kohli or a Sachin Tendulkar tweet about it? It's a cricket film, you know," Gupta says. But she does hope the documentary will be a conversation-starter. ■

Ishita Sengupta

Caught Out excavates a chapter in Indian sports history that many would like to believe never happened